



The gods wear
Viking clothing

A large crane
or goose looms
over Freyr

Runic
inscription
arches over
the scene

▲ Norse gods in Sweden

The figures in the lower panel of this stone are thought to be the gods Odin, Thor, and Freyr because they hold their attributes—a spear, hammer, and sickle, respectively. The same gods appear in the upper panel.

THE WAND-CARRIERS

Norse magic

In the centuries before Scandinavia's conversion to Christianity, which began in the 8th century, its Nordic people developed a rich body of myths and pagan beliefs. In their eyes, the world was ruled by the Norns, supernatural female beings who controlled fate, and also by two sets of warring deities, the Aesir, dominated by the gods Odin and Thor, and the Vanir, who included Freyr and Freyja. The Norse people believed that the world

was full of mythical creatures such as giants, elves, and dwarves, and that trees, rocks, rivers, and even homes were alive with *vættir*—spirits and demons. In response to all these beings they developed an elaborate belief system with magical elements.

Norse magic lore was almost never written down at the time. It survives mainly in later sagas, which might be clouded by a Christian perspective, and from a few archaeological relics, such as runes.